

Our focusChrist Joseph

EVIDENCE, INTERPRETATION AND THE CASE FOR RETAINING HIM

A consolidated study of the approved portrait: what the historical record supports, what it leaves uncertain, and what would justify a change.



The unchanged owner-approved portrait. A modern artistic interpretation, not an authenticated photograph or a forensic identification. [20]

Retain the approved Joseph

No demonstrated structural defect requires replacing him. Exact historical fidelity remains unverified. The evidence supports a cautious artistic interpretation and an optional, limited hair study.

Prepared for Wyatt. Use the navigation bar, Contents page, bookmarks and bottom buttons to move through the study. Underlined source titles open the original publications.

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Read the labels as limits

Supported means a source constrains the choice. Plausible means the portrait is compatible with the available record. Unverified means the claim has not been established; it does not automatically mean false.

The research verdict

Keep him as he stands

The approved portrait is defensible as an openly labeled artistic representation. A stronger claim - exact anatomy or recognition by a contemporary - is not established.

This conclusion follows an audit of the actual approved pixels, the museum mask histories, journal records, written descriptions and the supplied research. The portrait has a long oval face, prominent nose, lighter brown hair and fair complexion. It also contains pores, color variation, folds and unequal contours. Generic criticism that it is textureless or perfectly symmetric does not describe this image.

Why a rebuild is not presently warranted

No appropriately matched, reproducible comparison has shown a particular structural error in this portrait. Absence of a measured match is not evidence of a mismatch. A replacement should correct a demonstrated material inconsistency or implement an informed artistic choice, not manufacture certainty by starting over.

The most reasonable optional study

The swept waves and hair volume are less firmly constrained than broad facial structure. A restrained, straighter-haired variation could be useful, with light lashes considered separately. Natural texture and arranged hair are not identical questions. Neither change is currently a proven correction. [12]

What the conclusion does not claim

It does not assign an accuracy percentage, authenticate a photograph, recover an exact eye shade or identify every individual skin mark. It does not prescribe changes to the nose, jaw, eye spacing, iris color, age or scars. The current approved image remains the comparison baseline.

The independent research reviews converge on retaining the portrait. They differ on how strongly a hair change is warranted. That remaining artistic judgment is preserved rather than turned into unanimous certainty.

Masks and life-derived art



The mask as a structural anchor

The original molds date to 29 June 1844; the surviving casts have uncertain manufacture dates. They record postmortem surface contours. Copying, repairs, missing regions and soft-tissue changes limit literal comparison. Related casts are not independent anatomical witnesses. [1]

Joseph death-mask reference as used in the current focusChrist study. The mask photograph is provided for source context, not as a pose-matched overlay or proof of agreement. [1, 20]

Maudsley: a documented sitting, several objects

The journal records a profile sitting on 25 June 1842. The museum says the original sitting drawing is unidentified. Hatch describes the 1982 discovery more precisely as a probable map-source painting; this may resolve Sweat's broader wording if different objects are meant. Neither should simply be equated with the sitting drawing. A profile constrains silhouette, not all frontal dimensions. [2, 3, 5, 23]

Rogers: use within its documented limits

September 1842 journal entries document painting sessions. The familiar oil is attributed to Rogers, with object history and artistic accuracy still requiring care. Curator Robert O. Davis challenges Hatch's scaling and camera-angle assumptions and argues for greater weight to the oil. Its criticism supplies no automatic correction to our portrait. [4, 5, 22]

Descriptions in their own time

The date of a meeting and the date a description was recorded are separate facts. A late firsthand memory may be valuable; it is not a contemporary entry simply because the remembered event occurred in Joseph's lifetime.

Record	What it contributes	How it is weighted
Davis letter, 6 February 1840 [7]	Estimated Joseph as 40-45 when he was 34.	Contemporary impression; apparent age can mislead.
Taggart letter, 10 September 1843 [6]	Young-looking near thirty-eight; approachable to the observer.	Contemporary letter with archival provenance.
Quincy letter, 16 May 1844 [8]	Several days' beard growth and clothes on the visit.	Contemporary, occasion-specific observation.
Quincy memoir, 1881-1883 [8]	Familiar eye, nose and forehead description.	Later recollection, distinct from his 1844 letter.
Pratt autobiography; Knight biography [9, 10]	Color, build, manner and grooming traditions.	Posthumously edited memoir / later mediated biography.
Gazette description attributed to May 1844 [11]	Hazel eyes, fine light hair and notable lashes.	Verified here through later transcription; original issue not inspected.
Haven letter dated 1843, published 1890 [21]	Blue eyes, light hair/complexion, youthful stout build.	Actual 1890 scan inspected; original manuscript unchecked.

These sources do not form a simple vote. Independence, record date, editing and transmission matter more than the raw number of quotations. The conflict between hazel and blue therefore remains explicit.

Trait audit: facial structure

01 Face length and breadth

What is visible. Long oval face, broad upper face narrowing toward the chin.

Evidence and decision. Masks and the Gazette transcription constrain broad shape; no pose-controlled ratios for this image were established. [1, 11] Retain; no justified narrowing or widening.

02 Forehead and brow structure

What is visible. Broad textured forehead, fine lines and substantial brow.

Evidence and decision. Masks and profiles are relevant; later Quincy wording is not a contemporary measurement. [1, 3, 8] A proposed slope change first needs a matched profile.

03 Nose

What is visible. Long prominent bridge, rounded tip and visible alar breadth.

Evidence and decision. Masks and Maudsley matter most. A criticism of Rogers is not a demonstrated defect here. [1, 3, 5] Retain; no evidence-derived rotation, narrowing or millimeter adjustment.

04 Mouth and upper-lip region

What is visible. Noticeable skin distance above the mouth, moderate upper lip and fuller lower lip.

Evidence and decision. Skin distance and red-lip thickness are different observations. The transmitted Gazette description is not a precise anatomical measurement. [11] Retain; define the feature before proposing a change.

Trait audit: chin and living eyes

05 Chin and jaw

What is visible. Firm chin with rounded-square corners.

Evidence and decision. Mask coverage, repairs and orientation limit comparison. Round/square verbal labels are not measurements. [1] No justified width or projection correction has been demonstrated.

06 Iris color

What is visible. Blue-gray appearance in this rendering.

Evidence and decision. Haven's 1843-dated letter, published in 1890, adds independent blue-eye support. Later blue recollections coexist with the Gazette hazel description, transmitted later. [8-12, 21] Blue is defensible, but exact shade is unresolved; no compulsory recoloring.

07 Eye depth and lids

What is visible. Open attentive eyes, natural lower-lid folds and unequal contours.

Evidence and decision. Closed postmortem lids do not determine living aperture; illumination affects apparent depth. [1] Do not invent droop or copy the death-state eyelids as a living face.

08 Brows and lashes

What is visible. Substantial brows; lashes less conspicuous than the Gazette description.

Evidence and decision. Long light lashes are a source lead, not a measured specification. The original newspaper image remains unverified here. [11] An understated lash study is optional, not a proven correction.

Trait audit: hair and complexion

09 Hair color

What is visible. Brown with lighter strands and highlights.

Evidence and decision. Descriptions support a lighter brown/dark-blond range, influenced in appearance by age and light. No exact colorimetry was established. [9, 11, 12] Retain the general range; no precise color value is recoverable.

10 Hair texture and arrangement

What is visible. Swept hair with visible wave and volume.

Evidence and decision. Fine, straight natural texture creates tension with the coiffed appearance; arranged waves alone do not establish natural curl. [12] Less wave and volume is the strongest optional study, not a compelled identity correction.

11 Complexion and skin detail

What is visible. Fair skin with warm/red cheeks, pores, freckle-like marks and folds.

Evidence and decision. A light complexion has support; each mark and degree of redness remain interpretation. [9-12] The actual pixels defeat a blanket smoothing criticism. Do not add artificial grime or aging.

12 Facial hair

What is visible. Clean-shaven appearance.

Evidence and decision. Retrospective sparse-beard descriptions and Quincy's contemporary several-day growth can coexist with changing grooming. [8, 9] Retain for a general portrait; stubble belongs to an appropriate dated scene.

Trait audit: age and presentation

13 Apparent age

What is visible. Mature adult, plausibly in his late thirties.

Evidence and decision. Contemporary impressions disagree: Davis estimated older, Taggart younger-looking. Joseph died at thirty-eight. [6, 7] Do not age him merely to look historical. Each future scene needs its actual date and age.

14 Expression

What is visible. Calm, attentive gaze and closed mouth.

Evidence and decision. Descriptions of manner do not prescribe one permanent expression. [6, 9] Retain as an artistic choice. Historical recognition cannot be assigned a defensible percentage here.

15 Asymmetry and scars

What is visible. Unequal brow, lid and mouth contours; no prominent diagnostic scar.

Evidence and decision. An unproven photograph's supposed scar or eye droop does not establish Joseph's living marks. Preserve natural variation; invent no diagnostic mark to manufacture agreement.

16 Build and clothing

What is visible. Bust in a dark coat and white neckcloth.

Evidence and decision. A bust cannot establish stature, weight or full-body shape. Quincy describes different occasion-specific clothing. [8, 9] Retain the period-plausible presentation without certifying exact clothing or body fidelity.

Decision and conditional construction

Present decision: retain

No replacement identity is proposed for approval now. Preserve this portrait and its honest interpretive labeling.

A bounded study, if later chosen

First define a dated scene or an explicitly late-Nauvoo portrait at about age 36-38. Identify the exact mask objects, Maudsley variants and Rogers-attributed work, including copying and repair relationships. Disputed photographs are not ground truth.

Before any structural change, demonstrate a stable material discrepancy in appropriately matched views. Record missing contours, perspective limits and independent reviewer disagreement. Design landmarks can document source consistency; they cannot supply identity probabilities or a forensic authentication. Unrestricted warping can manufacture an apparent fit. [15]

If a visual study is selected, test restrained hair first, with lashes separately. Keep other traits fixed so the comparison is meaningful. Current evidence supplies no replacement nose, jaw, eye spacing, iris shade or scar.

Evidence that would change the verdict

A repeatable mismatch that survives source condition, pose and analyst uncertainty; a newly authenticated contemporary depiction; or new original documentation could change a trait. A pleasing overlay or subjective confidence cannot substitute for those results.

Approval remains separate

Any future variation should receive independent historical and visual review before use. Adopting a new identity or publishing it remains a separate owner decision. A well-presented study or a technically sound image does not itself establish historical accuracy.

How our portrait was created

A documented artistic process

The project record describes a reconstruction informed by museum death-mask references. It does not establish a measured recovery of every living feature. [27]

The historical-identity record identifies Joseph's death masks as the primary proportional reference and Hyrum's as comparative material. It records the exact image adopted by Wyatt on 14 September 2026 as the identity reference for future Joseph scenes. [27]

A mask cannot supply living eye color, skin color, hair, expression, clothes or light. Those parts of the finished portrait are artistic choices informed to differing degrees by historical description and period context. Joseph and Hyrum were distinct people; comparison does not make their faces interchangeable.

What the creation record does not establish

The reviewed project record does not include a contemporaneous landmark measurement log or a complete original generation prompt. We therefore cannot certify that every dimension was measured against a cast, or that every source in this study was used during creation.

Creation and later research are separate

This audit examines the retained image against a broader historical record. Sources newly recovered during the audit strengthen or qualify our assessment; they are not retroactively described as original design inputs. The exact approved pixels remain the comparison baseline.

Why the distinction matters

A transparent process explains why the picture was made as it was. Historical accuracy still depends on the evidence for each feature. A documented workflow and owner approval establish provenance and acceptance of the artwork, not authentication of Joseph's exact living appearance.

Discovery coverage and remaining gaps

The investigation combined the supplied research with a broad, documented public-source search: Joseph Smith Papers, Church museum and library material, BYU Studies and RSC, digitized books and periodicals, newspaper catalogs, and methodological literature. This is not an exhaustive search of every internet page, archive or private collection.

What the expanded search changed

Haven's 1843-dated letter was verified in its 1890 publication. It strengthens the blue-eye choice and adds light complexion, youthful stout build and round shoulders. The original manuscript remains unchecked. These details do not validate every feature of a bust. [21]

Davis's critique shows why a mask-to-portrait ratio is not automatically decisive. His preference for greater weight to the frontal oil is a substantive alternative, not proof that the oil is exact. Hatch's map-source account also refines the identity of the Maudsley object rediscovered in 1982. [22, 23]

Conflicting descriptions stay visible

The descriptions do not all agree. Caswall's large hands contrast with the Gazette's small hands; youthful and older-looking impressions coexist. Hostility, memory, editing, viewpoint and occasion can affect descriptions. We retain the conflict instead of counting quotations as votes. [6, 7, 11, 26]

Still unresolved

The original Gazette issue, Haven autograph, complete chains for some art objects, and a controlled measurement of our portrait remain gaps. Additional nondigitized and private records may matter. None of those gaps is proof that the portrait is wrong; neither is their absence a reason to call it exact.

The revised conclusion is therefore specific: the evidence supports retaining this interpretation, but does not substantiate every visible trait or prove it is the closest image that could ever be made.

Sources: original records and art

[1] [Church History Museum: Joseph and Hyrum Smith death masks](#)

Institutional object history; original molds and surviving casts distinguished.

[2] [Joseph Smith journal, 25 June 1842, manuscript p125](#)

Contemporary sitting entry; artist identification also uses JSP annotation 251.

[3] [Church History Museum: Lt. General Joseph Smith, Maudsley](#)

Object-specific gouache provenance; distinguish original sitting drawing.

[4] [Joseph Smith journal, September 1842, manuscript p205](#)

Contemporary Rogers-sitting context and editorial identification.

[5] [Anthony Sweat: Joseph Smith in the National Portrait Gallery](#)

Scholarly art history; pp 354-356 and 362-365. Includes attribution and recollection limits.

[6] [Ronald Barney: Susannah and George Taggart letter, 10 September 1843](#)

Scholarly transcription of contemporary letter with archive provenance.

[7] [JSP: Discourse, 5 February 1840; Matthew Davis letter dated 6 February](#)

Original letter and historical introduction; age impression tied to actual date.

Sources: descriptions and review

[8] [Jed Woodworth: Josiah Quincy's 1844 Visit with Joseph Smith](#)

Transcription of 16 May 1844 letter; distinguishes 1881-1883 recollection.

[9] [Parley P. Pratt: Autobiography, chapter VI](#)

Accessible 1888 edition; first published 1874 with posthumous editing. Retrospective firsthand account.

[10] [Susa Young Gates \(Homespun\): Lydia Knight's History, 1883](#)

Later third-person biography, not a contemporary Knight autograph.

[11] [The Birth of Mormonism, appendices, 1916](#)

Transmission of Gazette description attributed to 18 May 1844 issue. Original newspaper image not verified here.

[12] [Janet Thomas: What Did Joseph Smith Really Look Like? December 2005](#)

Institutional synthesis; not itself a contemporary eyewitness document.

[15] [FISWG: Facial Comparison Overview and Methodology Guidelines v2.1](#)

26 February 2026, sections 6.2-6.4. Professional method limits; this report is not an expert forensic examination.

[20] [focusChrist: Joseph Smith likeness study and approved portrait](#)

Current public interpretation and source-use statement. Exact approved image preserved; public bytes matched. Process description is not measured historical fidelity.

Review record: the source and pixel audit received independent research review. Remaining judgments are identified in the text. Exact image and review records are retained with the project evidence; they establish which artwork was examined, not its historical fidelity.

Sources: expanded research and process

[21] [Charlotte Haven, A Girl's Letters from Nauvoo](#)

Letter dated 22 January 1843; December 1890 Overland Monthly, printed p. 621. Original publication scan inspected; autograph letter and editorial transmission not checked.

[22] [Robert O. Davis, review of Joseph Smith Portraits](#)

BYU Studies 38:4, p. 185 onward. Museum curator's direct methodological criticism of Hatch's scaling, viewing angle and treatment of the frontal oil; not measurement of our portrait.

[23] [Ephraim Hatch, Joseph Smith Portraits, p. 34](#)

BYU digitized book page. Distinguishes the Young Family map-source painting found in 1982 from the Smith Family versions and hypothetical retained sitting drawings.

[26] [Henry Caswall, The City of the Mormons](#)

Contemporary 1842 account, compared with the 1843 edition. Hostile source with edition differences; large hands conflict with Gazette small-hands wording. No iris-color specification adopted.

[27] [focusChrist historical identity and creation record](#)

Project record at the retained production revision. Distinguishes the documented mask-based creation account from this later audit.

The final source set distinguishes contemporary documents, later publication of contemporary-dated letters, later recollections, art-object scholarship, institutional synthesis and the modern project record. Search logs and access failures are preserved with the private research evidence.